Northwind Vela Owner's Manual (Excerpt)

Edition 2026. This excerpt covers hybrid driving, refuelling, charging, the combustion engine and towing. It applies to all markets unless a section states otherwise.

1. How the plug-in hybrid works

The Vela combines a 2.0-litre turbocharged petrol engine with an electric motor integrated in the 8-speed automatic transmission. Energy for the electric motor comes from a 22 kWh high-voltage battery, which you charge from the mains and which is also partly recharged by regenerative braking. With a charged battery, the Vela drives electrically for most everyday journeys. When more power is needed, or when the battery is depleted to its minimum level, the petrol engine starts automatically. The battery is never fully emptied while driving; a reserve is always kept so that the hybrid system can support the engine and start it smoothly.

2. Hybrid driving modes in detail

Hybrid mode is the default whenever you start the car. It uses electric drive as much as possible at low and medium speeds and starts the engine when you accelerate hard, drive faster than about 140 km/h (87 mph), or when the battery is depleted. If a destination is entered in the navigation system, Hybrid mode plans the use of electric energy along the route, for example saving it for a city section at the end of the journey. Electric mode drives purely electrically until the battery reaches its minimum level; the engine still starts if you press the accelerator past the kickdown point. Save mode keeps the current battery charge level so that you can use it later, for example in a city with a low-emission zone. Charge mode uses the engine to charge the battery while driving, up to a level you choose between 30% and 80%; this increases fuel consumption considerably and is only recommended when you need electric range later and cannot charge from the mains. The selected mode is shown in the instrument cluster.

3. Refuelling

The fuel filler flap is on the rear right wing. Because the engine may not run for weeks if you mostly drive electrically, the Vela has a pressurised fuel tank. Before opening the flap, press the fuel button on the driver's door panel or on the touchscreen and wait until the message "Ready to refuel" appears, which can take up to 15 seconds while the tank pressure is released. Use unleaded petrol with at least 95 RON (87 AKI or higher in the United States; 91 AKI recommended). E10 is approved in Europe and E15 is not approved in the United States. If the car has not used the engine for a long time, it will automatically run the engine for a short period to keep the fuel and engine in good condition; a message informs you when this happens. Fuel that is more than one year old in the tank is detected and the car will ask you to drive in Hybrid mode to use it up.

4. Charging the Vela

Charge through the port on the front left wing with a Type 2 cable in Europe and the UK, or a J1772 cable in the United States. With a 7.4 kW wallbox (7.2 kW in the US), a full charge takes about 3.5 hours. In Europe and the UK, the Vela can also use DC chargers at up to 50 kW, charging from 10 to 80% in about 25 minutes. Charging overnight and starting each journey with a full battery gives the lowest running costs and emissions.

5. Engine maintenance

Even though the engine runs less often than in a conventional car, engine oil ages over time and must be changed according to the service schedule for your market. Check the engine oil level using the touchscreen under Vehicle > Engine oil; the car measures the level electronically when the engine is warm. Top up only with oil approved to the Northwind LL-26 specification, 0W-20 viscosity. Do not overfill.

6. Towing

The Vela is approved to tow up to 2,000 kg braked (3,500 lb in the United States) with the factory tow bar. When towing, select Trailer mode under Vehicle > Towing: it adjusts the stability control, keeps the engine available at all times and holds the battery charge to support acceleration. Expect higher fuel consumption and less electric range when towing.